

Where Did All the Honest People Go?

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Essay

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A humorous but serious look at how personal accountability has faded from everyday life, from broken plans and ignored messages to lies dressed up as misunderstandings. The essay argues that honesty does not require perfection, but it does require the basic decency to keep your word, admit when you are wrong, and make things right when you fall short.

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Where Did All the Honest People Go?

There was a time when making plans involved a phone attached to a wall, a calendar with a picture of either a barn or a beach on it, and a general assumption that people were not lying to you for sport.

You would call someone and say, “Hey, we’re having people over Saturday. You coming?”

And they would say, “Yeah, I’ll be there.”

Then, and I know this sounds like pioneer fiction now, they came.

Not always on time, of course. Let’s not get carried away and pretend the 1980s and 90s were some lost civilization of perfect manners and polished shoes. People were late. People forgot things. People got lost because MapQuest had not yet blessed us yet with its printable chaos, and GPS was still something astronauts probably used while regular people argued in the front seat of a Buick. But for the most part, when someone said they were going to do something, they did it.

If they said they were coming to your party, they showed up unless they were actively on their deathbed. And even then, there was a decent chance they would call.

“Hey, sorry, I can’t make it. I’m seeing a bright light and Grandma’s waving me over.”

Fair enough. That’s a valid excuse. We can reschedule the potato salad.

What I miss is not some fantasy version of the past where everyone was noble and honest and every handshake carried the moral weight of the Constitution. People lied back then, too. People flaked. People cheated, stole, blamed others, made excuses, and occasionally behaved like raccoons in pants. Human nature has not exactly been trending upward since the invention of fire.

But something did feel different.

Your word meant something.

Not because everyone was morally superior, but because there was still some basic shame attached to not keeping it. If you said you would be somewhere and you didn’t show, you knew somebody was going to ask. Not in a “please process your lived experience” way, either. More like, “Where the hell were you?”

And you were expected to have an answer.

That expectation mattered. It was not perfect, but it created a kind of social guardrail. You could still drive into the ditch, for sure, but at least everyone agreed the ditch was not the road.

Right now, I’m not always sure we agree on that.

We live in a time when a person can say they will do something, not do it, ignore three messages about it, later claim they never agreed to it, then somehow make you feel rude for bringing it up.

That is an impressive amount of work to avoid one simple sentence: “I messed up.”

Apparently that sentence has become radioactive.

Nobody wants to touch it. Nobody wants to stand too close. We treat personal responsibility like it's a suspicious container at the airport. Better call in a specialist. Clear the area. Maybe blame the algorithm.

The modern excuse machine is really something to behold. There is always a reason now. Always a circumstance. Always a context. Always a feeling. Always some foggy, half-formed explanation that cannot be questioned without you becoming the problem.

"I didn't lie. I just didn't have the full truth available to me at the time."

No. You lied.

"I didn't ignore your message. I was protecting my peace."

No. You ignored my message.

"I wasn't late. Time has been weird for me lately."

Time has been weird for everyone since 2020, but the dentist still charges you if you miss the appointment.

And to be fair, life is complicated. People are overwhelmed. Everyone is busy. Everyone is tired. Everyone has a phone that is both a productivity tool and a tiny casino of distraction. I'm not pretending I have never missed a text, forgotten a commitment, or looked at my calendar with the same horror usually reserved for finding a raccoon in the attic.

I have. In true Rob fashion, I have probably created my own problems, acted surprised when they arrived, and then complained about the packaging.

But there is a difference between being human and being allergic to accountability.

There is a difference between "I dropped the ball" and "Actually, the ball experienced a breakdown in communication."

We have become unbelievably creative at avoiding blame. The modern person can build a whole legal defense around forgetting to pick up folding chairs. There will be diagrams. There will be emotional context. There will be a detailed explanation of how expectations were unclear, even though the expectation was, "Bring the chairs."

And somewhere in the middle of this nonsense, honesty gets treated like aggression.

That might be the strangest part.

You can catch someone in a lie now and still end up on trial.

You say, "Hey, you told me this was done, but it wasn't."

They say, "I don't appreciate your tone."

Now we are no longer talking about the thing that was not done. We are talking about your tone. Your timing. Your approach. The emotional safety of the person who lied to you with the confidence of a man selling miracle vitamins at a county fair.

And suddenly you are standing there, holding the truth like a bag of groceries with the bottom falling out, wondering how this became your fault.

That is the gaslighting part. I know that word gets thrown around too much, and half the time people use it to mean “someone disagreed with me,” which is not the same thing. Disagreement is normal. Misunderstanding is normal. Two people remembering something differently is normal, especially if one of them is over forty and has opened the refrigerator three times looking for the ketchup staying me in the face.

But when someone plainly says one thing, does another, and then tries to convince you that your memory, expectations, or basic sense of reality are the problem, that is not a misunderstanding.

That is dishonest.

And it wears people down.

It wears down trust. It wears down patience. It wears down the part of you that wants to give people the benefit of the doubt. Because after a while, you start to feel like a sucker for believing anyone at all.

That is a sad way to live.

I do not want to become the guy who assumes everyone is lying. Nobody likes that guy. He forwards articles in all caps and starts every conversation with “You know what the problem is?” I do not want to be him. I have met him. He has strong opinions about electric cars and which shampoo is bad for the environment.

But I also do not want to become the guy who pretends nothing is wrong while basic honesty gets treated like an outdated family heirloom nobody knows what to do with.

Because something is wrong.

It shows up in little ways first. People don’t RSVP. People ghost. People make plans they have no intention of keeping. People agree to deadlines they know they cannot meet. People say “circling back” when what they mean is “I ignored this until it became uncomfortable.” People tell partial truths and act wounded when anyone notices the missing pieces.

At work, it becomes “I thought someone else was handling that.”

In friendships, it becomes “I’ve just had a lot going on.”

In families, it becomes “That’s not what I meant.”

Online, it becomes “Show me exactly where I said that,” even though the screenshot is sitting right there like a crime scene photo.

My kids tell me to "prove it." Like I have every single word or action recorded, time-stamped, and searchable at a whim.

And in public life, it becomes almost a sport. Say anything. Deny anything. Change the story. Blame the media. Blame the other side. Blame the intern. Blame your childhood. Blame Mercury being in Gatorade or whatever the astrology people are mad about this week.

Nobody is responsible. Everyone is misunderstood.

That's where things are at.

Now, I know every generation thinks the next one is ruining civilization. Somewhere in ancient Rome, a father probably looked at his son's sloppy toga and said, "These kids have no discipline." Then he walked uphill both ways to a forum and complained about grain prices.

So I try to be careful with the phrase "today's generation." It is too easy. It lets people my age sound wise when sometimes we are just tired and annoyed because someone parked badly at Walmart.

And honestly, the problem is not only young people.

Plenty of adults my age and older have become experts in dodging responsibility. We taught some of this. We modeled some of this. We built a culture where convenience beats commitment, where feelings often outrank facts, where every mistake requires a public relations strategy, and where being "right" matters more than being honest.

Kids did not invent that.

They inherited it.

We handed them phones before we handed them judgment. We gave them endless ways to avoid uncomfortable conversations. We turned every disagreement into a performance. We taught them that reputation is something you manage, not something you earn. Then we act shocked when they treat truth like a setting they can adjust.

That's on us, at least partly.

Still, I do think something has shifted. Accountability used to be more local. More immediate. More human. If you lied to somebody, you had to look at them eventually. At school. At church. At work. In the driveway. At the grocery store while your mom compared prices on ground beef.

There was no blocking your way out of it. No muting the conversation. No disappearing into a digital fog and reappearing later with a vague post about boundaries.

You had to face people.

That did not make everyone honest, but it made dishonesty cost something.

Today, the cost often feels optional. You can ghost a friend, stiff a small business, lie in a group chat, abandon a commitment, and then just float away into the next thing. New circle. New job. New platform. New version of yourself. No forwarding address for your character.

And maybe that is part of the problem. We have made it too easy to start over without making anything right.

I believe in second chances. I believe in grace. I believe people should be allowed to grow, change, learn, and not be permanently defined by their worst moment. A big part of me is deeply grateful that my teenage stupidity was not preserved forever in high definition. If the worst things I said at fifteen had been recorded, captioned, archived, and searchable, I would currently be living under an assumed name in a cabin with no Wi-Fi.

So I am not arguing for a world where every mistake gets punished forever. That is its own kind of sickness.

But grace is not the same thing as pretending nothing happened.

Forgiveness is not the same thing as no accountability.

A second chance usually requires a first honest admission.

That is the part we keep trying to skip. We want the comfort of forgiveness without the discomfort of confession. We want people to move on without us having to say what we did. We want clean slates, but we do not want to clean anything.

At the end of the day, accountability is not complicated. It is not some elaborate moral software update. It is basic.

You said you would do something. Did you do it?

You made a mistake. Did you admit it?

You hurt someone. Did you try to make it right?

You lied. Did you tell the truth when it mattered?

That's it. That is the whole exam. No essay section. No bonus points for using the word "trauma" correctly in a sentence.

And yes, there are hard cases. There are abusive situations. There are unreasonable people. There are times when boundaries are necessary, when silence is safer, when explaining yourself to someone only gives them more rope to tie you up with. I'm with you. Not every accusation deserves your emotional labor. Not every demand is fair.

But we cannot use the hard cases as cover for ordinary cowardice.

Most of the time, accountability is not dangerous. It is just uncomfortable.

And we have become very bad at being uncomfortable.

We want every conversation softened. Every correction padded. Every consequence delayed. Every failure reframed. We want honesty, but only if it arrives in a tone we approve of, at a time that works for us, with enough compliments around it to make it feel like a spa treatment.

That is not accountability. That is customer service for the ego.

Real accountability stings a little. Not because it is cruel, but because truth has edges. If you made a promise and broke it, someone pointing that out is not automatically attacking you. If you lied and got caught, the problem is not the catching. If someone says, “Hey, this hurt me,” your first job is not to assemble a defense team inside your head.

Your first job is to listen.

Then, if they are right, say so.

That sounds simple, but it may be one of the harder things for people to do now. Maybe it always was. Pride is not new. Excuses are not new. Adam blamed Eve, Eve blamed the serpent, and the serpent presumably blamed market conditions.

Still, there used to be more respect for the person who owned up.

You might not like being wrong, but you understood that admitting it was part of being decent. A person who could say “That was on me” earned something. Trust, maybe. Respect. The sense that even if they failed, they were not going to make you crazy pretending they didn’t.

That kind of person is gold.

Not perfect. Not always smooth. Not always right. Just honest enough to be trusted.

I think that is what people are really missing when they ask, “Where have all the honest people gone?” They are not asking where the saints went. Most of us have never had many saints in the group chat. They are asking where the regular honest people went. The ones who showed up. The ones who called if they couldn’t. The ones who did not need a notarized document to remember what they promised. The ones who could say, “You’re right, I should have handled that better.”

People like that still exist.

They are just quieter than the excuse-makers.

They are the friend who texts back even when the answer is awkward. The coworker who says, “I missed it, but I’ll fix it.” The kid who admits they broke the lamp before constructing an alternate theory involving the dog, wind patterns, and possible paranormal activity. The spouse who says, “I was wrong,” even though every cell in their body would prefer to argue about tone and timing until one of you dies.

These people are not flashy. They do not make accountability their brand. They just live it in small, boring ways.

Small and boring is where character usually lives.

That may be why we miss it. Modern life rewards noise. It rewards performance. It rewards the confident lie, the polished excuse, the dramatic self-explanation. A person quietly keeping their word does not trend. Nobody goes viral for showing up when they said they would, unless they arrive on a unicycle while rescuing a baby raccoon.

But ordinary honesty is what holds everything together.

Families need it. Friendships need it. Workplaces need it. Communities need it. You cannot build anything lasting with people who treat every commitment like a suggestion and every truth like a negotiation.

You can survive that way for a while. You can make excuses. You can keep everything vague. You can avoid the hard conversation. You can protect your image.

But eventually, people stop believing you.

And once that happens, it is hard to get back.

Trust does not usually die in one dramatic explosion. It dies from small unpaid bills. A missed promise here. A half-truth there. A defensive reaction every time someone asks a fair question. A pattern of making other people carry the weight of your choices.

Then one day, someone does not ask anymore.

They just adjust.

They stop inviting you. Stop depending on you. Stop telling you the important thing. Stop expecting you to show up.

And you may think you got away with it.

You didn't.

You just became someone people plan around.

That is the serious part for me. Accountability is not about punishment. It is about repair. It is how people stay connected after being imperfect, which, unfortunately for all of us, is our main activity as human beings.

Without accountability, every mistake becomes a fracture. Every lie becomes a wall. Every broken promise becomes one more reason to keep your distance.

And I do not want to live in a world where everyone keeps their distance because nobody can admit they were wrong.

I want my kids to know that honesty still matters, even when dishonesty seems easier. I want them to know that saying "I'm sorry" is not weakness. I want them to know that if they give their word, it should cost them something to break it. Not because I want them crushed by guilt, but because I want them free from the exhausting business of pretending.

Lying is work.

Avoiding responsibility is work.

Keeping track of your excuses is work.

It is a hell of a lot easier, in the long run, to be the kind of person who can sleep at night because you did your best, told the truth, and cleaned up your mess when you didn't.

Not perfectly. Nobody does it perfectly.

But honestly.

Maybe that is where accountability has to start again. Not with a national campaign or a viral lecture or some guy on the internet yelling into a microphone from inside his truck. Maybe it starts with boring old personal conduct.

Call when you say you'll call.

Show up when you say you'll show up.

Tell the truth when lying would be easier.

Apologize without attaching a twelve-page legal brief.

Do the thing.

And when you don't, say, "That was on me."

It will feel weird at first. Almost old-fashioned. Like writing a check at the grocery store or leaving a voicemail with your full name and phone number even though the person can clearly see who called.

Oh well.

Some old-fashioned things are worth keeping.

Your word should mean something.